

Maseca Tortillas

Masa-harina path · toasted-masa + lard upgrades · the no-grinder route toward El Milagro

YIELD	ACTIVE	HYDRATION	MASA MOISTURE
~28 @ 32 g	~45 min	~115% (start)	55–60%

FORMULA

baker's % of Maseca weight — scale to your batch

Maseca masa harina, yellow — toast 100 g of it (step 1)	100%	400 g
Water, hot ~110–120°F — start here, dial by feel	115%	460 g
Lard melted into the water — pliability + keeping	4%	16 g
Salt fine	1.25%	5 g

STAGE 1

MAKE THE MASA

Play-Doh that doesn't crack at the edges is the whole game

- 1

Toast a quarter. Dry-toast **100 g of the Maseca** (no oil) in a comal/skillet over medium, stirring, until it smells **nutty and just barely colors** — **3–5 min**. Don't brown it (turns bitter). This puts back toasty depth that drying strips out. Stir it into the other **300 g**.
- 2

Hydrate. Melt the **16 g lard** into the **460 g hot water**. Stir the salt into the Maseca, then pour in the lard-water **gradually**, mixing as you go.
- 3

Knead. Work **2–3 min** to a smooth **Play-Doh** — press a ball flat: **smooth edges, no cracks**. Too dry → add water 5 ml at a time; too wet → dust in Maseca.
- 4

Rest. Cover with a damp towel, **20–30 min** — the masa fully hydrates and firms. Re-check the smush test after; it usually wants a touch more water.

HYDRATION CHECK

all one question — is the masa at 55–60%?

TEST	WHAT YOU WANT	IF NOT
Smush test	Press a ball flat — edges smooth, no cracks	Cracks = dry: add water 5 ml at a time
Earlobe test	As soft as an earlobe; clean release from your hands	Too dry: + water. Sticky/wet: dust in Maseca.
Float test	A pea-sized ball floats in water	Sinks = under-hydrated; knead in more water

Press & Cook

STAGE 2PRESS & COOKthree flips — the third is the puff

- 1

Portion: roll **32 g balls** (~28 total), smooth, keep covered so they don't skin over.
- 2

Press: ball between plastic (a cut produce/zip bag) — press once, **rotate 180°**, press again to an even **~1.5 mm**, no thin spots.
- 3

Cook, 3 flips: dry comal at **400–450°F (IR)**. **Side 1** ~15 sec until the edges set and lift; **flip 1** ~40 sec until light spots appear; **flip 2** back to side 1 — it should **puff** (nudge the edges with a towel).
- 4

Steam-rest: stack into a towel-lined container and **cover immediately** — the trapped steam is what keeps them soft and foldable.

IF IT WON'T PUFFalmost always one of three

SYMPTOM	CAUSE	FIX
No puff, stiff	Masa too dry, or pressed too thick	Hydrate up; press to ~1.5 mm
Cracked edges off the press	Under-hydrated masa	Knead in water 5 ml at a time
Sticks / gummy	Comal too cool, or masa too wet	Recover to 400–450°F; dust in Maseca

STORAGEreheat on the comal, never cold

Towel-lined container, room temp	Best within 4 hr — eat fresh.
Wrapped / paper bag, fridge	5–7 days — reheat on the comal 10 sec/side.
Freezer, stacked + separated	1–2 months — comal from frozen, or damp towel + microwave.

Endgame upgrade (next batch): cut the Maseca 50/50 with **Masienda** heirloom masa harina — the closest a dried flour gets to fresh stone-ground El Milagro. Master the technique on straight Maseca first, then swap the flour.